

The Smile and the Laugh

*Understanding the Boundaries of
Humor and **Mockery** in the Light of
the teachings of the Ahlulbayt (pbut)*

*by
Syed Imon Rizvi*

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***In the Name of Allah,
the All-beneficent,
the All-merciful.***

Introduction

A Moment for Reflection

Dear brothers and sisters,
This booklet is for you, as you grow up in a society where joking and making fun of others is often considered a normal social behavior. In many of our cultures, particularly in the Indian subcontinent, this habit has become so ingrained that people often fail to see anything wrong with it. In friendly gatherings, on TV shows, and in daily conversations, making sharp remarks, taunting, and bursting into loud laughter are often seen as signs of being witty and full of life.

But have we ever paused to think about how the **Being** who created us views this act? In the Holy Qur'an, Allah (s.w.t.) explicitly states:

"يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لَا يَسْخَرْ قَوْمٌ مِّنْ قَوْمٍ
عَسَىٰ أَن يَكُونُوا خَيْرًا مِّنْهُمْ..."

("O you who have believed, let not a people ridicule [another] people; perhaps they may be better than them...") (Surah Al-Hujurat, 49:11).

This is a clear and unambiguous command that rejects all forms of mockery and ridicule.

This habit is not merely a social ill; it is a spiritual sickness that hardens the heart and makes it

heedless. When a person becomes accustomed to constantly mocking others and laughing loudly, their heart becomes numb to the remembrance of Allah, the concern for the Hereafter, and the feelings of others.

This booklet presents a few pearls from the invaluable treasure of wisdom we have inherited from Prophet Muhammad and his progeny (peace be upon them all). In the light of these luminous teachings, let us examine our own attitudes and see the delicate boundaries our infallible guides have drawn between humor, laughter, smiles, and mockery, so that we may become dignified,

thoughtful, and truly well-mannered believers.

Excessive Laughter

Chapter 1: The Downsides of Excessive Laughter and the Erosion of Dignity

Islam is not against good humor, but it is strictly against unrestrained and aimless laughter. In the view of the Ahlulbayt (a.s.), laughing excessively is detrimental to both a person's spirituality and their personality. It destroys one's dignity and deadens the heart.

1. Excessive Laughter Deadens the Heart

كَثْرَةُ الضَّحِكِ تُمِيتُ الْقَلْبَ

English Translation:

A great deal of laughter deadens the heart.

Reference: Ghurar al-Hikam:
102:2/33

The life of the heart comes from the remembrance of Allah and empathy for His creation. When a person is constantly engaged in joking and loud laughter, their heart grows weary of serious and profound matters. The memory of the Hereafter, remorse for one's sins, and the feeling for the suffering of the poor become meaningless to them.

This is the very state that the Imam (a.s.) has described as the "deadening of the heart." A major reason for the apathy we see in our society today is that we have filled

our lives with meaningless laughter
and amusement.

2. Excessive Laughter Destroys Dignity

كَثْرَةُ ضِحْكِ الرَّجُلِ يُفْسِدُ وَقَارَهُ

English Translation:

The excessive laughter of a man corrupts his dignity.

Reference: Ghurar al-Hikam: 97:2/44

Dignity (Waqar) is the jewel of a believer's personality. It is the awe and respect that Allah bestows upon His righteous servants. When a person laughs loudly in every gathering and makes light-hearted jokes with everyone, people stop taking them seriously. Their words lose weight and their respect diminishes. If a leader, a teacher, or the head of a household is

constantly laughing, their subordinates will cease to respect them.

3. Excessive Laughter Diminishes Awe

مَنْ كَثَرَ ضِحْكُهُ قَلَّتْ هَيْبَتُهُ

English Translation:

Whoever laughs a lot, his reverence diminishes.

Reference: Ghurar al-Hikam:
160:2/225

4. Excessive Laughter Leads to Humiliation

مَنْ كَثَرَ ضِحْكُهُ اسْتَذِلَّ

English Translation:

Whoever laughs a lot is debased.

Reference: Ghurar al-Hikam:
165:2/327

These two narrations describe two sides of the same reality. When a person's dignity and reverence are gone, they fall into the abyss of humiliation. People begin to make fun of them and disregard their presence. It is a psychological fact that a person who presents themselves as very frivolous and non-serious will also be taken lightly by the world.

Purposeless Laughter

Chapter 2: The Prohibition of Purposeless Laughter and Mockery

Sometimes, a person laughs for no particular reason or makes fun of others just to get a laugh. The Ahlulbayt (a.s.) have described this as an act of ignorance and a means of hurting others.

Laughing Without Reason

5. Laughing Without Reason is a Sign of Ignorance

كَفَى بِالْمَرْءِ جَهْلًا أَنْ يَضْحَكَ مِنْ غَيْرِ
عَجَبٍ

English Translation:

It is enough of a man's ignorance that he laughs without a reason for wonder.

Reference: Ghurar al-Hikam: 101:2/18

In our gatherings, it often happens that one person speaks and the rest begin to laugh at every sentence without reason. This, in fact, degrades the quality of the conversation and renders it meaningless. The Imam (a.s.) is stating that this is a sign of ignorance. A wise and discerning person laughs only when there is something genuinely amusing or wonderful. Laughing at everything

is evidence of intellectual emptiness.

Laughing which alienates friends

6. Excessive Laughter Alienates Friends and Emboldens Enemies

كَثْرَةُ الضَّحْكِ تُوحِشُ الْجَلِيسَ وَتَشِينُ
الرَّئِيسَ

English Translation:

Extreme laughter alienates a companion and disgraces a leader (in the eyes of his subordinates).

Reference: Ibn Abi al-Hadid: 20:259

لَا تُعَوِّدْ نَفْسَكَ الضَّحْكَ، فَإِنَّهُ يَذْهَبُ
بِالْبَهَاءِ، وَيُجَرِّئُ الْخُصُومَ عَلَى الْأَعْتِدَاءِ

English Translation: Do not accustom yourself to laughter, for

it takes away your splendor and emboldens opponents to transgress against you.

Reference: Dastur Ma'alim al-Hikam: 73

These narrations state a profound principle of social relations. A person who is always joking will find their serious-minded friends distancing themselves, as they cannot engage in any scholarly or intellectual conversation with them. Furthermore, this behavior signals to their opponents and enemies that they are a non-serious person who can be harmed easily. They become bold in attacking them.

Mocking

7. The Prohibition of Making Mocking Remarks

يَا بُنَيَّ! إِيَّاكَ أَنْ تَذْكُرَ مِنَ الْكَلَامِ مَا يَكُونُ
مُضْحِكاً وَإِنْ حَكَيْتَ ذَلِكَ عَنْ غَيْرِكَ

English Translation:

O my son! Beware of saying anything that is comical [at someone's expense], even if you are only quoting it from someone else.

Reference: Nahj al-Balaghah:
Letter 31

This is the advice of Mawla Ali (a.s.) to his son, Imam Hassan (a.s.), and it is a powerful wake-up call for us. Today's culture of "roasting" or "banter" is a clear

violation of this principle. People make fun of someone's appearance, clothing, family, or a mistake just to get laughs from the audience. The Imam (a.s.) is saying do not even let such words pass your lips, even if you are quoting someone else. How strict is this command! It means that being a party to spreading mocking and ridiculing content is as great a sin as creating it yourself.

Scholar's laughter

8. A Scholar's Laughter Diminishes His Knowledge

إِذَا ضَحِكَ الْعَالِمُ ضِحْكَةً مَجَّ مِنَ الْعِلْمِ
مَجَّةً

English Translation:

When a scholar laughs out loud, a portion of his knowledge is cast away from him.

Reference: Uyun Akhbar al-Ridha: 3:219

This hadith is a warning especially for people of knowledge, speakers, and those working in the path of religion. A scholar's dignity stems from his knowledge. When he laughs loudly like the common folk, he devalues his knowledge. This does not mean a scholar cannot smile, but rather that his laughter should also be subordinate to his knowledge and dignity, not boisterous and meaningless.

Believer's Laughter

Chapter 3: The Nature of a Believer's Laughter

If loud laughter and mockery are forbidden, then what kind of demeanor should a believer adopt? The Ahlulbayt (a.s.) have told us that a believer's face is cheerful, but their heart is sorrowful and concerned. The best form of laughter is a smile.

Believer's State

9. The Believer's Outer and Inner State

إِنَّ الزَّاهِدِينَ فِي الدُّنْيَا تَبْكِي قُلُوبُهُمْ وَإِنْ
ضَحِكُوا وَيَشْتَدُّ حُزْنُهُمْ وَإِنْ فَرَحُوا

English Translation:

Indeed, the hearts of the ascetics in this world weep even if they laugh, and their sorrow is intense even if they are outwardly joyful.

Reference: Nahj al-Balaghah: Sermon 113

Silence and Speech

10. The Silence and Speech of the Pious

إِنْ صَمَتَ لَمْ يَغُمَّهُ صَمْتُهُ وَإِنْ ضَحِكَ لَمْ
يَعْلُ صَوْتُهُ

English Translation:

If the pious one is silent, his silence does not grieve him, and if he laughs, his voice is not raised.

Reference: Nahj al-Balaghah: Sermon 193

These narrations describe the depth of a believer's personality. They do not laugh loudly at worldly, superficial things. There may be a smile on their face, but in their heart, there is sorrow for their sins, the pain of the occultation of the Imam of our Time (a.j.t.f.), and concern for the Hereafter. Their laughter is also dignified; their voice is not loud. This is the character we should strive to adopt.

Smile

11. The Best Laughter is a Smile

خَيْرُ الضَّحِكِ التَّبَسُّمُ

English Translation:

The best kind of laughter is a smile.

Reference: Ghurar al-Hikam:
349:1/18

This hadith is the essence of the entire booklet. The Ahlulbayt (a.s.) are giving us a beautiful and dignified alternative. Instead of loud laughter, make it a habit to smile. A smile is a symbol of love, warmth, and good manners. It connects hearts, whereas a guffaw makes a gathering frivolous. Our beloved Prophet Muhammad (p.b.u.h. & h.p.) often used to smile, and his smile won the hearts of people. This is the tradition (Sunnah) that we must revive.

Conclusion

The Choice is Yours

These teachings of the Ahlulbayt (a.s.) present us with two paths: **one** is the path of loud laughter, mockery, and heedlessness, which deadens the heart, destroys dignity, and ultimately humiliates a person. The **other** is the path of thoughtfulness, dignity, and a radiant smile, which increases a person's honor, keeps their heart alive, and makes them beloved to Allah and His creation.

Let us make a pledge today to purify our gatherings from mockery and meaningless laughter. We will not hurt anyone's feelings just to

make others laugh. We will adopt smiles instead of loud laughter.

We pray to Allah Almighty that He grants us the ability to follow in the footsteps of the Ahlulbayt (a.s.) and adopt their sublime morals, so that on the Day of Judgment, we may be among those whose faces are bright and smiling with the pleasure of Allah.

W a s s a l a m u A l a i k u m w a
Rahmatullahi wa Barakatuh.

Syed Imon Rizvi

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